

10

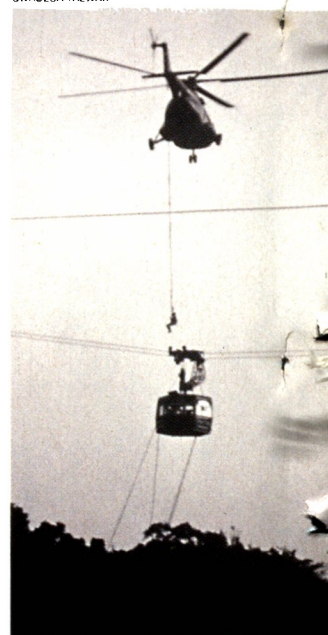
acts of valour

From the immortalised war cry of Captain Vikram Batra to the supreme sacrifice of Mumbai Police ASI Tukaram Ombale, from the Indian Army's only thrice-decorated soldier to a daring cable car rescue, the country, post-1975, has witnessed courage under fire from the sentinels of our borders and lives

3 Sky-High Bravery Major Ivan Joseph Crasto

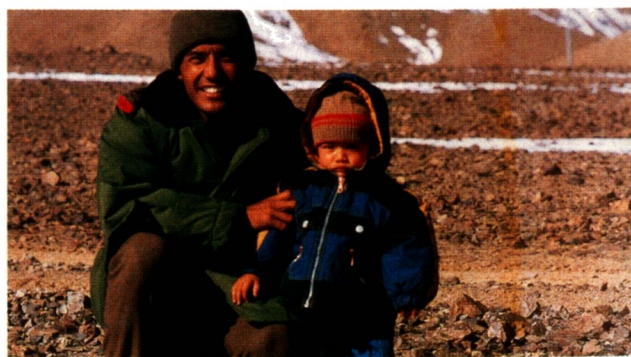
On October 13, 1992, a mountain cable car trolley at a resort on the Chandigarh-Shimla highway met with a freak accident and was dangling precariously 1,000 ft above the ground, trapping 10 tourists. In a breathtaking operation facilitated by the Mi-17 helicopters, 28-year-old Crasto, a para commando of the Indian Army, was heli-dropped into the trolley and rescued each passenger, getting them winched up one by one by the hovering copters. His mid-air bravado earned him the Kirti Chakra.

SWADESH TAL WAR



4 Three Times the Hero Naib Subedar Chunni Lal

One of the army's most decorated soldiers Chunni Lal received three gallantry awards for operations in Siachen and Jammu and Kashmir. Honoured with the Sena Medal, Vir Chakra and Ashok Chakra, he eliminated three terrorists in a fierce gun battle in the Kupwara sector of Jammu and Kashmir before falling to enemy bullets in 2007.

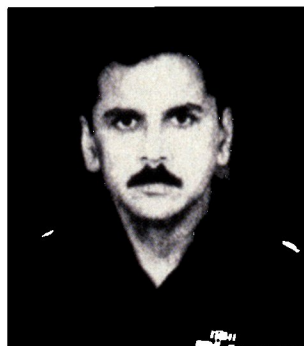
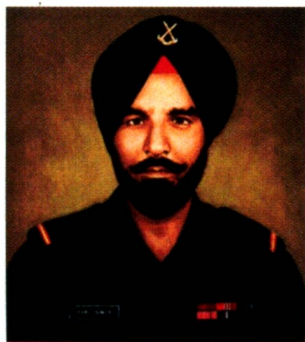


5 First Blood Major Sonam Wangchuk

The first breakthrough in the Kargil war came when Wangchuk captured an 18,000-ft-high mountain ridge in the Chorbat La sub-sector near Batalik. The mountains rang with the war cry, "Ki Ki So So Lhargyalo" (The gods will triumph), as he led his men to snap shut an infiltration point (INDIA TODAY June 21, 1999).

1 Vertical Limit Naib Subedar Bana Singh

The iconic soldier of the 8th Jammu and Kashmir Light Infantry has the rare honour of a 22,143-ft-high post on the Siachen Glacier field named after him. Earlier known as Quaid and later renamed Bana Top, this post was controlled by the Pakistan Army prior to June 1987, when 38-year-old Singh surprised the enemy with an audacious assault and captured what was then considered an impregnable glacier fortress with 1,500-ft-high vertical ice walls on either side. For this act of valour, Singh was presented the Param Vir Chakra on January 26, 1988.



2 Mortal Combat Major Ramaswamy Parameswaran

Major Parameswaran, the company commander of the 8th Battalion of the Mahar Regiment deployed in Sri Lanka as part of the Indian Peacekeeping Force, was leading his patrol back after a search operation on the night of November 25, 1987, when his column was ambushed by Tamil Tigers. He encircled the attackers and charged at one of them in hand-to-hand combat. Despite sustaining a bullet wound on his chest, he grabbed a rifle from his assailant and shot three militants dead before succumbing to his injuries.